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Carol Sudhalter

Carol Sudhalter first pursued a career in biology but eventually followed her passion for jazz. She has played flute and saxophone with Latin Fever, Etta Jones and Chico Freeman, and recorded numerous CDs as a leader. Carol founded the Astoria Big Band and is a member of the Jazz Journalists Association.

Carol was interviewed in New York City on January 14, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Manhattan. I'm very pleased to have Carol Sudhalter with me. Thanks for making the trip into town today.

CS: Thank you.

MR: And recently back from Italy you said?

CS: Yes.

MR: How do you get gigs in Italy?

CS: Yes. It's not as hard as it might seem since I go way back. My first trips to Italy were in the late 60s. I have seen, with the advent of the internet basically, big changes. And it's no longer a question of writing a letter and waiting three months for the reply. We can send an email. And what I do, I have a lot of friends both in the music production aspect and just friends, musicians and people who love music, in Italy. So I just send a massive email to everyone I know who could possibly be interested in helping, and some people come back with yes, I would have a gig for you at that time.

MR: Then do you have to try to string them together?

CS: I try to avoid zigzagging around the country if I can help it, but if I have to I'll do that. I buy basically a Eurail pass and then I can take all the trains I want.

MR: That's neat. And I would assume you sort of have to be prepared to work with different levels of rhythm section and musical skill as well as personality.

CS: This is true. This is true. Personality-wise, no I think pretty much I get along pretty well with — I think generally Americans and Italians on the social level, we appreciate each other tremendously and, you know, we see their country as being very hospitable and very tasty food-wise, and so forth, and they see us with our enthusiasm. And I think it's a great — I'm not talking about governments or anything but just on the personal level I think it's a perfect match. So I get along well with my Italian friends and rarely have a problem. The levels of accomplishment, sometimes yeah, sometimes I might appreciate a drummer from New York more than a drummer from Italy because they have the

authentic way. But it's not every drummer. That's just something I occasionally run into. A certain rhythm, if I call a certain rhythm or a certain tune, they just don't always know as much what to do with it.

MR: Okay. Now do you carry music with you, like lead sheets?

CS: They usually write and ask me for a list in advance so that they can look over the music and I do carry a few sheets, not many. I used to carry much more but now we have of course all these little programs on the iPad and most musicians over there have those too.

MR: Oh right.

CS: So they can pull up — and then they can always take pictures of the music so I don't have to bring copies for everyone.

MR: It's a strange new world.

CS: It's getting easier.

MR: It's getting easier, yeah. Yeah I can recall those days of putting a letter in the mail with your package, or you're sending things out to little record companies.

CS: You've got it. That's right.

MR: You're waiting and waiting. And then I used to save a list, I called it my no folder, right? Thanks for your letter but no.

CS: That's right. That's exactly right.

MR: Well I had a question I was going to save until the end but I'm going to ask you now. This career in music, why did you do it?

CS: Oh it's a great question, okay. And I'm glad you didn't save it for the end because it takes some times to answer. I was a biologist. I was a biology major and I loved, since I was a kid I was an insect collector, I didn't play with dolls. I collected insects and I watched birds and that's what I liked to do. And people gave me nature books for my birthdays and stuff. And so I got to college and I was a biology major and I wanted to be a science writer on the popular level, like Rachel Carson, to show alternative methods of pest control that would not be toxic to the world, and so forth. And that's what I was studying. And then I fell into a depression when I was 20 and I started going to therapy, which was I think the right thing to do, and today, and then you know, always. So over the course of the first five or six months in therapy I began to get in touch with a different part of myself. Let's say maybe it was the true core, and that was an interest in music, which I had always had but I never thought of it in the same way. And I started thinking, out of the blue kind of, gosh, I follow all these bands around and sort of a groupie and I like to date these crazy musicians. But why don't I ever think about playing something myself, an instrument. And that was the thought that came to me. And then from there I thought well what the heck could a girl play in the world of jazz? I never thought a girl could play

So I thought well I'd play a flute. So I asked around and someone in my dormitory had a flute that she wasn't using and loaned it to me and I began to immediately try to start playing along with my records and I ran downtown and tried to sit in with the local band even though I still didn't know where G sharp was and so forth. And so from there, you know, it got worse and worse. And I didn't know at the beginning that I wanted to make it a career, I just knew that I was spending a lot of time sort of skipping meals so I could practice along with my records, and trying to do this. And people would say well why are you doing this, it's so late in life, and what do you want to do with it, you can't possibly be a musician if you don't start at five years old. And I just said maybe that's true but I don't know. I have no way of knowing what I want to do with it. I'm just doing it because my gut is telling me to do this and I can't refuse it.

MR: Can I ask you what records you were playing along to?

CS: Oh sure. The records I had at that time were Billie Holiday, the one that's called "Lady Day" I think. And I had Django Reinhardt records but I don't think I tried playing along with that, and Frank Sinatra. So I would say Billie Holiday and Frank Sinatra. My father was a very good alto sax player who was wonderful at playing obbligatos.

MR: I see.

CS: So that's something that I immediately started to try and do.

MR: You were using your ear to play in the cracks?

CS: Correct.

MR: That's actually good training.

CS: Yes it is.

MR: Like listening to the vocalist and like waiting and then —

CS: And trying to play in their style in a way, and then you hear the other instrumentalists who play behind them and what they do.

MR: So your father and your brother Richard were already doing music.

CS: Yes. And that's what I heard since I was quite young. I heard my father playing along with his records ever since I was born, and also practicing the various etudes and concertos and stuff.

MR: At what point did they, or either one of them, see this passion growing in you and did they comment on it?

CS: Well my father was appalled. He was absolutely aghast. Because — my brother didn't care too much — he didn't mind too much one way or the other I don't think he took a huge interest in my life really. He was pretty involved in his own thing. But my father had really — I mean when he was a young sax player in Boston he used to play these gigs and he would go and play at Smith College and all these society places you know.

And he said well if I ever have a daughter, this is the cat's pajamas. This is where it's at. If I ever have a daughter she should go here. So he began —

MR: So you were at Smith. I'm not sure we said that.

CS: Yeah. He began saving money for this eventual daughter to go to Smith. So when I hit like 15 he started telling me this is where I want you to go and please go look at it. And I did and I couldn't tell whether, what it was. I couldn't really perceive anything just from looking overnight. And so I said well okay, and I sort of really wanted to go to Oberlin, because that's where my brother went, but I said okay. I got into Smith so I went there. And then I started seeing really what it was, and this tremendous class structure, and the snobbery and maids and oh my God — I just — how can I even survive here. It was just so unlike anything that I ever knew or wanted. But, you know, we'd get on the phone long distance, every week or so, and he'd say no, please don't transfer, please stick it out, you know, one day you'll be glad to be a Smith girl. Well anyway, just I'll say that he was so appalled that I could have become anything I wanted in life except a musician, for him you know. So here I was in my sort of last year of college turning and wanting to get into the world of jazz, which he felt was the most unacceptable one.

MR: Interesting because he — I guess he could have been happy being that he was a player and the joy he may have got out of it. But instead, at the same time, he had seen the realities of being a performer.

CS: He had. And he had terrible memories of things, like going on a cruise and seeing the way musicians treated women, and that kind of thing. You know, he thought of all the worst things. Not the satisfaction. So I guess that had to do with how people feel about their daughters or something. So it was terribly hard for me, because I just hated disappointing him, but I knew I had to do it. And my therapist actually was quite encouraging. So that was a nice thing.

MR: I've heard that sentiment stated in a similar fashion before, that if you're going to go into the music world, and especially jazz, you better have to do it. If it's just a passing fancy then —

CS: It wouldn't work, no. And I was willing to do a series of part time jobs. We were talking about transcribing, and I did many years as a medical transcriber. Anything that — I tried full time work but I just wasn't able to get any practicing in. So I went to part time jobs that didn't take a whole lot of concentration. I like transcribing. I'm good at it. Because I'm good with language and different other kinds of jobs like that you know, and odds and ends of translating as well and editing and stuff.

MR: Did you have circumstances where you went to sit in with groups and were sort of looked like, oh really? You want to play with us?

CS: Oh definitely. Oh my God, yeah. I remember the first time I went to Israel that was sort of 1965. And I walked into a club and I said, "Can I sit in?" And they said, "Well what kind of music do you play?" I mean why would I even be there if I weren't playing their style of music? That's so silly. And they were very snobby about it. And it happened many times in the 60s, many times. People just didn't — and then they felt too that they had to just sort of make a pass at you if you were there playing in a band or sitting in. It wasn't like they'll talk shop with you and support you. It had to be that kind of —

MR: That dynamic was almost expected or something.

CS: Yeah. And I did see the change over the decades. I mean I'm not saying it's perfect today but I did see a change in that. And of course now, I mean nobody would make a pass at me even if I wanted them to. I mean I'm a band leader and nobody touches that. It's the funniest thing.

MR: You're the person with the paycheck.

CS: I guess. I guess that's it. I mean they won't even make a comment — and it's not just now, I mean I'm in my 70s now so I don't expect a lot, but in my 60s and my 50s, when I was still sort of rather attractive, I mean I already noticed that. That when you're the leader, in New York, it's just not part of the ethic. They don't make those comments, "You're looking hot" or whatever they might — it just doesn't happen.

MR: Were there role models for you, man or woman, coming up?

CS: Yes there were. And that was a great big factor for me. What happened was that in the subsequent decade, that is when I was 32, my father died and I decided sort of the next day, if not right at the funeral, that now I'm going to also play the saxophone. And I got hold of the sax, it wasn't his at the time, but I started practicing. But I didn't think of joining a band until I heard, her name is Lisa Brown. She was an alto sax player who was playing around in Boston in some different Latin bands. And I went to see her. And as soon as I saw her playing it was like now I've seen a woman playing saxophone, now I'm going to go join a band. And then I got into my first band, which was a Latin band. And yeah, it was very important to me.

MR: Was it a tenor you started out on?

CS: I did. I started on tenor, yeah. I'm pretty sure I started on tenor.

MR: Mostly taught yourself?

CS: No I started taking lessons.

MR: Oh okay.

CS: Yeah. And I'm trying to think — I know one of the big teachers I had, but this was a little bit later — I'm trying to think who I studied with in Boston because I know there was someone — maybe I'll think of that later. But I went to Eddie Barefield in New York, he

colors he got out of the tenor, you know, the beautiful nuances and color, and especially when he played like Strayhorn tunes, and I wanted to get an idea about that. And it was very interesting, the lessons with him, because he was very insistent on learning the lyrics to songs before you played them. And I think that's where the color came from — understanding the meaning of the song in terms of the lyrics.

MR: Boy, he did a lot of session playing I believe — rock & roll and just about everything that came along.

CS: Big Nick was amazing that way, yeah. I mean you can hear him in big bands. And when he would do the Jazzmobile he would take any popular song like "Hot Hot Hot" or something like that, and make it into a beautiful jazz tune, and he was always sort of dancing while he played and then he'd sing.

MR: That's right. He was just written up in the *New York Times* a few months ago. Because I think he passed away not that long ago.

CS: No it's been quite a long time.

MR: Okay. Well it must have been an anniversary or something.

CS: It must have been.

MR: Yeah. Okay. So you're on your way to become a musician and —

CS: And I had classical flute teachers. I sort of made up my own style of jazz on flute. I knew what I wanted and I found it. It was a very percussive style for a long time, and I listened to sort of Harold McNair, Jeremy Steig, Frank Wess, just everybody I could get my hands on.

MR: Yeah. Was getting gigs for you more about finding them yourself rather than being called as a sideperson?

CS: I would say yes. Yes. Finding them myself and what you're saying is exactly right. I mean I don't think, as I remember it, I didn't get called as a sideperson for many years following forming my own groups and being leader and playing as leader of a quartet or big band or whatever. Then, after many years and then getting established, then people would call me as a sideperson. It really didn't happen first.

MR: Did you have a particular style of jazz that you pursued? Were you going to be a bebopper? Or is that too simplistic?

CS: I wish I were a bebopper. I really don't have the language, you know, the way some people do. There might be hints of it in my playing. But my — in one book, Royal Stokes' book, he put me in the chapter "keepers of the flame." I guess that a lot of people find elements of Lester Young, Coleman Hawkins in my playing on tenor. And my, well one of my super favorites is Lucky Thompson. So, even though they're all so great, all the tenor players.

CS: Yeah. And then on flute I kind of always drifted a lot towards the Latin, that percussive, pungent sort of style. But I love playing obbligatos too, and ballads, and almost any era I guess. I liked to play the really really old tunes too, 30s tunes in a humorous way. And then on baritone I mean I leaned toward seeing it as a very lyrical, melodic instrument, rather than a punching out those — I like doing those too — honking out the notes. But for some reason I just find it a very —

MR: Or the, was it Nick Brignola, who like he could play bop on the baritone like he was playing an alto.

CS: Just like it was nothing, yeah, Nick and Pepper, oh my God they just — so marvelous, I would love to — but that's not within my reach. It's just something I can't do.

MR: How do you — you mentioned you have a lot of students. Have you ever had a student that seemed to have an innate ability to improvise and find cool things, and you felt loath to mess with them?

CS: You mean to change what they're doing?

MR: Yes.

CS: Ah. What a great question, oh my God that's such a deep question.

MR: Well I've had one or two over the years.

CS: I guess you must have, to say that, yeah.

MR: And the funny thing is is that I could tell they didn't quote from a theoretical standpoint know what they were doing. That sounds like — that's a downer. But it's not.

CS: No, no it's not.

MR: Like I wish I could do that.

CS: Yeah I hear you.

MR: Like I'm thinking to myself well do I try to get this person more hip to the chords and the note choices or should I just don't mess with it.

CS: Yeah, you don't know what your role is, I know. Well I have three students right now who are super interesting, and one is exactly like that. He's a kid that — I mean he doesn't really know if I put a piece in front of him is this in the category of classical or jazz. He doesn't know anything about terms or theory. He can just barely know what key he is in or something. But when I put on a blues on the speaker with an iReal background, or a "Watermelon Man" or whatever, you know, he will just make the most wonderful choices of notes and phrasing, and pauses — exactly the right pauses that all beginners forget to do, you know, leave that space. He does all that. And he comes out with the most amazing things. And I know that his grandfather was a jazz musician but I don't know whether he ever heard him, but I mean there's something there in the family line. And so yeah, I think to myself well I can't approach him the way I can some other — it's

try to get him to understand what the notes of the chords are you know. At the most I might just show him a blues scale or something like that, and just point out that he is already using those notes you know. But just to help him know the name of what it is. But yeah, it's a very very delicate question. And years ago I had a very deep experience in that category. Not so much with the improvising but with messing with what's already been happening. A gentleman brought me his son, who was probably about seven or eight. And he said, "I want you to give him piano lessons. He's never had a lesson." And he played straight through some very very difficult piece — a sonata or a concerto, something, I don't remember what it was, either Mozart or Beethoven or something straight through. And of course there were lots of mistakes in the rhythm and stuff because he had just learned it — maybe from his father rather than from listening to the record. But he had incredible technique, incredible ear and memory you know. And then I sort of, I really hadn't been teaching so long at that time. Now it's going on 50 years I think. So I took him back to a beginner book to help him count and read. And I think it was just the completely wrong thing to do. I should have just left him right where he was because I think he felt it was an insult. And his father came to me and said he's starting to have nightmares about the piano, and so then they dropped the lessons. And I realized that I had interfered with the connection that was so intimate for him, you know, with his instrument, that I never did that again.

MR: Yeah. Boy that's a learning experience.

CS: Um hum. And well anyway now I have two other kids. One is learning very quickly. He can read anything. He's about maybe 12 I guess. He can read anything I put in front of him, flawlessly, and he's learning Charlie Parker solos perfectly. And then a second kid who is doing something very similar and they're both showing a lot of talent. But I can work with their improv, if I make a comment about chords. Like the first one, he understands a II-V-I progression and he understands when he's not on that, and he hears it. So that's going well.

MR: And when Mom and Dad come to you and say what do you think about my son or daughter making a career in music, do you have a — what do you tell them?

CS: Well so far, I mean I don't think any of these people are really thinking that at this point. I think they look at it like with sports — like something that's going to help them get into college. Or I don't know. But I mean if they said it or if they do occasionally say it to me, or if the kid says it, then I try to just explain to them, you know, that it's not easy and if they want a lot of money they shouldn't do it.

MR: Right. That's a bit of an oxymoron — I'm going to go into jazz to make money.

CS: Yeah. I mean if you're a person who needs a lot of money to live comfortably than you

as a musician basically the way that I know to do it is to play a Broadway show. So you have to be a good doubler.

MR: Right.

CS: They make, I think, a ton and then it's fairly stable. Or maybe not so much now but I mean some shows close and some are cutting down on their orchestras.

MR: Yeah. It's almost like having a nine to five except it's more like a, whatever, seven to ten.

CS: It is. And playing the same thing every night couldn't be too much fun but yeah, if you're a person who wants to marry, have kids, have a house, have a car, then you can't fit being a jazz musician into that unless the person you marry has a stable career. I would tell them things like that. Yeah, I mean it's clear.

MR: What's your favorite thing to do as a musician?

CS: Oh yeah. I like house concerts.

MR: Okay. Tell me about that.

CS: I love doing house concerts and I try to organize them myself and I've been pretty successful. I've done them in several countries. And well what you need to do is I have a little document that I wrote up about this that I give to people but you know you find a space — it doesn't have to be — I mean it could be just someone you know who's willing to let you use their house. You have to explain to them that that's not something that they're going to get money from. Then you put out the word that there will be this concert, let's say a trio. You probably don't want a quartet with drums in the house, most houses no. It could be an apartment even. You put out the word but when you put out the flyers you don't write the address and you have to make it sort of reservations only so that you don't have somebody just walking in who's a nut, to someone's house. So you know in advance who made a reservation and then you charge at the door whatever fee seems to be acceptable, $15 or $20 is usually what can go over. And then I usually offer to provide the refreshments because I live by Costco and for $30 I can provide great food for a party. And then maybe someone's going to bring a little bit of pot luck, maybe not, and maybe the host wants to supply drinks, again, maybe not, but they'll tell you if they do. And then so you have a little time of socializing and snacking. And you need X number of chairs, 15 to 30 usually, couches or chairs. Everyone sits very quietly for the house or hour and a half, you have your band play. And then I guarantee to put everything exactly back where it was, and I do that. And it's just — I mean the energy that goes back and forth at that close distance, like with us, it's so powerful. And I don't know, I mean if I'm playing for a big audience somewhere I suppose that's a thrill, but this is my favorite thing.

MR: I know exactly what you mean. I think having people close to you in small numbers is

when you play. Like they're right there, you look at this person — if you're in a big hall you just kind of look anywhere.

CS: That's right, anywhere. And you're just like breathing each other's energy. Sometimes I almost can't believe the notes that come out in those circumstances. Did I just play that? I've never played that before. You know, that kind of thing.

MR: It makes me think of the anecdote you told me about going to Hamilton College and participating in what you think was a Bach piece and that you said it affected you so much that you couldn't even speak.

CS: I really had trouble talking for a couple of days.

MR: I think that says a lot about your level of empathy with music I guess.

CS: I hope so. I criticize myself because I have a terrible — you know most of my friends who are musicians, everyone in Italy but also most of my friends here, you know remember every album they've listened to, the name, the cuts, who played on them, they've got it all catalogued, you know, what they read, the books they read. Everything goes in my mind and out, I have so little retention. I think does this mean I'm too superficial about music, but it's just — I hope that what you're saying is the greater truth.

MR: Okay. Do you notice in your students sort from the get go, like this student has something that's going to make improvising easier for them.

CS: In their personality? That's a great question too. Oh my God. I hesitate to make that connection. I suppose it is true. I would want to say that it might be true but sometimes, sometimes that ability seems to be pop out of the most unlikely people too so I don't want to generalize or overlook anyone.

MR: Right. Sometimes — I guess I think of the — like a junior high kid who, some of them are so afraid of making a mistake that they'll play one note and then they'll go oh —

CS: It's true, yes, absolutely.

MR: And the rare one, they're a little bolder I suppose is maybe part of it.

CS: I'm still puzzling as a teacher over certain things like ear training. Like why is it that when you try to get someone to figure out a tune like "Happy Birthday" that they can't hear that the first and second notes are the same.

MR: I know.

CS: Isn't that something that the brain naturally knows. I guess not. But why?

MR: I know. You're going like this — I sometimes try to use hand signals.

CS: I do as well.

MR: Yeah.

CS: And then does it go up or down from there, and why can't they hear that? Why can't they hear when your voice changes and goes up or down. But anyway there's always

MR: Are you still a learner? Speaking of learning?

CS: I try to attend as many — whenever I hear of a master class I try to go. I recently attended one on clarinet. I can't remember the names of the two players, they were both great and it was like half and half — half the day and half the day — with these two amazing clarinetists teaching different students. And you know, I mean yeah, I try to learn, watch videos, go to master classes, whatever I have time for, go listen to players and I think that we always keep learning yeah, definitely. And plus I mean I've never learned to arrange and that's something I still want to do. You know I have a big band. I guess you know that, or maybe you don't. But it's not my arrangements. Only one is something I arranged. But we've had the band since 1986 and I'm the bari player of course. And we get grants to perform and we have writers that write for us, and the biggest part of our library is by Charlie Camilleri, who is now gone, passed away, but he was — he wrote I would say over 40 or 50 arrangements for us.

MR: And what's it like trying to organize and get a gig for a big band?

CS: Well when you have a grant it's pretty easy. Other than that it's just about impossible. Most of the big bands around town, they work for $10, $15 dollars and I just can't ask people to do that.

MR: Isn't that tough? I just was noticing someone's group is at Birdland tonight — a Berger? David Berger maybe?

CS: Oh yes, I did see that, yeah.

MR: And I often wonder well how does that work? How do you play all those people? Do they mostly do it, like it's an off night and —

CS: You know I mean especially if you know I think the most offers that come in for big band are to play the old nostalgic kind of repertoire. And to pay people $10 to do that it's really insulting. I mean I guess that David Berger — probably people are going because the arrangements are worth playing. Almost any jazz musician will do a rehearsal band. We have lots of rehearsal bands in New York City. If you go up to the union on 48th Street, any time of any day, just walk in and you'll hear some band rehearsing with beautiful arrangements. Some big band, and usually the leader has written all the arrangements. And people say sure, I'll make it, because they want to play that new music and I belong to one that rehearses on Wednesday nights at the union. It's been going for 15, 20 years. And the leader is a dentist who plays trumpet. He doesn't write the arrangements but he has massive drawers full of collections of every arranger you could imagine. And then people can bring their own as well. In the classical world it's not like that. I mean if you have a trio or a quartet rehearsing and you call people and say can you make our rehearsal, "Well how much are you going to pay me?" But in the jazz

good arrangements and I would guess that David Berger's situation tonight might be the same, or maybe he is paying well with a grant, I don't know. But probably not. The opportunity to play at Birdland, and then the opportunity to play something that's really quality — or maybe he has his students playing. Who knows? I think he teaches at a major Manhattan school or something. Juilliard or something.

MR: Right. Why do you suppose that is with the classical people?

CS: They're just used to a different thing. I don't know, I don't know. But I've had certain pieces that we needed to play in the big band that needed a violin or a cello or something as an adjunct, and they were very rigid. I guess they go more by the union rules and so forth, probably.

MR: Okay. So when you're leading your own group and you have a gig or gigs coming up and you're rehearsing, or even on the gig, what would cause you, what kind of thing would cause you to tell one of your band members to please don't do that.

CS: I do have one. I mean he will just walk out onto the stage and set up anytime he feels like it, even though the audience is sitting there and the curtain should be closed. And I try but he's got a funny personality.

MR: I know exactly what you're saying, yeah. It's like that's part of the presentation actually.

CS: Absolutely. Or talking while I'm talking. That's something that really throws me off, talking to the person beside you, just chatting on the stage, when I'm trying to talk to the audience. Even if it's a quartet or a trio or a big band it doesn't matter, I just cannot concentrate when that other thing is happening, so that's something that I really get a little thrown by.

MR: Are you able to say knock it off?

CS: Yeah. I mean I can't not do it. I just — I try. It doesn't always work but — I mean sloppy dress that kind of —

MR: Okay. Isn't that interesting that you just said three things that would bug you, like that hammering in the hallway. But they were not playing things. So I think that says a lot, that musicians have to realize that the way they play is extremely important but that's not the end of it.

CS: I agree, yeah. I mean usually the players that I hire are hip enough so that there's very little to criticize. I would criticize something maybe in rehearsal but once you're at the gig I think professionals are just so good in New York that it would be hard for me to criticize anybody's volume or phrasing or anything. At that level they just have it.

MR: I sometimes ask the question what is the state of jazz in your opinion?

CS: Yeah, that comes up a lot. It's really hard for me to say. I think jazz — I mean it's never going to have the place of other genres that get millions of people interested. That's just

popular, I just don't feel like I can judge that. I know it's very hard for jazz clubs to stay alive financially. The rents in New York are off the wall. You know, they open, they close, if they want to stay alive they have to pretty much do something else like the Iridium is downstairs from a very successful diner where they have singing waiters, and they're both owned by the same person so that's how they get most of their income.

MR: Oh, so one helps pay for the other.

CS: The Stardust Diner or something, yeah. And then some of them start to mix genres and then they don't — they get sort of less interested in jazz. And that's annoying to us, and that's a trend, and I guess there's not much we can do about it.

MR: Are there places in town where people still dance to jazz music?

CS: Oh yeah, yeah, well big band jazz most times, yeah there is. Like Red Blazer too I think it's called Swing 46 now. Yeah. Swing 46. And there's a few other places. And then in other cities you get those, it's very nice. So yeah I mean I was lucky. I played at a jazz brunch from like 1990 to 2005 with a quintet that was just amazing and it was always full. They had it every Sunday and they served New Orleans cuisine. And the leader was named Jimmy Butts — Jimmy "The Face" Butts. He was an old bass player that had worked as a journalist as well. He was like he wrote for the *Amsterdam News*, he was a comedian, he could dance and sing and he was a wonderful bass player who had played with lots of great people. And his associate, Doc Pittman, who played the cocktail drum, you know it's a stand-up drum you play it —

MR: Oh. With brushes a lot?

CS: With brushes, yeah. And they were great entertainers. And Doc, I don't know how he even made it to the club he was so old, and sort of limped along, but he brought four outfits so that he could change four times, one for each set. A powder blue suit with hat and jewelry and then a red one and a white one. And we would have these routines going and I just learned so much about the business and my playing just grew so much. It was just amazing. And they were so, like like if I even leaned my elbow on the piano while I was on stage, Jimmy would say, "Get your elbow off the piano, what is that?" You know? Just, you know the proper demeanor and the proper entertainment, which goes back to our discussion about not just being a musician. Like if I came in in a dress, "Where are your nylon stockings?" I mean —

MR: They weren't afraid to point that out.

CS: Absolutely. And once I got off the stage because I was dizzy and Doc screamed his head off at me.

MR: Because you were what?

CS: I was dizzy or something. He said, "This is entertainment. You don't — there's no such

applied to himself. I mean that's how he did it. You have to look him up. Jimmy Butts and Doc Pittman. I mean they were just amazing. And the way they would fight like an old couple or something and not speak to each other. And they were just amazing. So I got a lot of training there.

MR: Things you can't learn in college.

CS: Oh definitely not. It was called The Cajun Restaurant. And I still have like some videos on those old cassettes — videocassettes, that we made. I mean Doc had his own language. He had his own vocabulary. He would say, "Well I dig your ground pads." That meant he liked your shoes. And he would call everyone Jack when he was telling a tale. "That's the way it goes, Jack."

MR: I love that. I got to play once with Claude "Fiddler" Williams. And we were in the middle of a tune and he goes, we're coming near the end and he goes, "George Washington." "What?" And then so I went to the bridge, so I go, "Oh, George Washington."

CS: Oh the bridge.

MR: That was his name or he'd say, "Channel."

CS: Oh the channel. Doc always said the channel.

MR: I didn't know what a channel was.

CS: Yeah the channel was the bridge. That's right.

MR: But George Washington, I read that Lester Young did that. But that inside language is so cool.

CS: When he said, "Top," he never said top, he said, "Left hand corner."

MR: Oh. You know I feel compelled to try to get my older students to be ready for when those things happen on the bandstand but you can only do so much. You have to experience it.

CS: Yeah. I try too. I try to let my students know that they can't get distracted when a baby cries or somebody screams or you get these strange things happening in the audience, or a fire engine. It takes a lot of discipline to do that. In Italy of course we play in the village squares a lot in the summer. And at 9 or 10:00 sharp, right in the middle of a tune, bong-bong. You know? From the steeple.

MR: Try to work that into your solo.

CS: Sometimes nature takes care of it and it just fits right in.

MR: Wow. So back briefly to the women in jazz. In the 70s there were some women jazz festivals and so forth, and a concerted effort to sort of level the playing field a little bit. Did you participate?

CS: Absolutely yes. And I have to say that if you're not familiar with this person, one of the great people to spearhead that was Cobi Narita. N-A-R-I-T-A and her real full title is Nobuko Cobi Narita. She's in Wikipedia. So I mean she's covered a lot on the internet.

now. But I mean she would organize these jazz festivals and get hold of a club and then hold you know all these concerts of women in jazz and do huge, beautiful publicity, great flyers with blown-up shots. You had to give her a blown-up shot with you playing with the horn really prominent. And she really just knew the whole business and all the angles and what to do, how to promote, and always keeping up with who were the players coming up on the scene, the women, and making sure to fit them in, and the older players. And what she did was just incomparable.

MR: Yeah. I used to get emails I think, of the events, and I always meant to try to hook up with her.

CS: Oh so you did, yeah.

MR: Yeah. Wasn't her husband Paul Ash?

CS: Paul Ash. That was not her first husband, but yeah, they were married later in life. Yeah. And he helped provide some venues and so forth, and a lot of support and donations and so forth. But you know she had a really fascinating background because when she was 13 or 14 I think she was put into one of those —

MR: Oh internment camps?

CS: Internment camps for Japanese here in this country. And even then, within the camp, she was organizing people into bands so that sort of tells you something.

MR: The "Jazz Angel."

CS: Yeah. So I did, I got to play, and at some point I had an all-women band.
[pause to adjust mic]

MR: Anything coming up in the near future that you're looking forward to?

CS: Well you know I have my new CD, that, it was a live concert here in New York at St. Peter's that came out real good, on baritone and flute and I sang for the first time, I sang one of my own tunes. And I just went to Italy to promote that and the gigs I did there were to promote that CD, because it just came out, and actually the release date here is officially January 18 so it's not even yet. And so what I plan to do is organize as many gigs and tours around that as I possibly can. Because I think it's a good representation of who I am right now. It has its flaws but so do I and you know, it's like where I am, so I feel good about that. And so I can't say exactly right now, I mean I lead a jam session at Flushing Town Hall once a month on Wednesdays and I have a very good rhythm section there and I get to do a lot of playing. We play before we start inviting people up, we play a few tunes, and that's a stable thing. And I work pretty regularly at Cleopatra's Needle, that's uptown. So I'm going to be trying to organize some concerts at some of the clubs. There's a pianist and organ player from Italy, Carlo Barile who has got a new album of his "Manhattan Suite," it's a jazz suite about Manhattan. And he's going to be coming

I'm going to approach Mezzrow and see. Because he's a very high quality player and we want to try to do this together. So I hope that this year will be, I think it probably will be a fruitful year.

MR: Is that like get on the phone and call this club or do you have a more up to date way that —

CS: Well I know that you're supposed to have an e press kit, which I really don't. And it would be nice to have an agent, which I don't. But I think that the steps that probably for me seem very important to take are (1) sticking your nose in the clubs from time to time, just be on the scene, which I don't do enough but I know that it's very important. Maybe sit in, maybe not, but just even just go say hello to people. Then of course contact the clubs either by phone or email and drop your CD and present in some way a sheet of paper that explains your project, and then be willing to go through that awful humiliating processing of calling back and calling back and calling back. And all those things count for a lot.

MR: Do the clubs in New York generally have a standard rate that they would pay for a group?

CS: You mean a standard rate of zero.

MR: A standard rate of zero or do they make you pay? I mean I've heard clubs, or maybe not in jazz but I know there's some clubs where the bands actually have to pay.

CS: It's true. I mean there's so many great jazz musicians. They come from all over the world and then the students graduating from the colleges, and the clubs really do know that they have a free meal. So they tend not to pay union scale. There may be one that does, I don't know. And some will just pay you what they get at the door or a percent of that. I recently had a club ask me to run the Sunday afternoon shows and hire the band and be the guest artist and, you know, that's a fairly heavy responsibility. And when I asked about what my fee would be or how much could I pay the bands, that was my first question. They said, "Well whatever comes in at the door we give 70% of the door." So that put me in a position of being one of them. You know I'm supposed to call bands and then ask them to play and give them this great opportunity and then say, but you only get —

MR: You don't even know what you're going to get.

CS: That's right. And then I ask what my fee would be for doing this and he said, "Oh well we'll give you a percent of their percent." So that made it even more exploitative. And so you know I had to say no even though I would have loved to have that job on Sundays. I mean it's a good opportunity for me to play as well with whoever you want to hire. But how can you do it without money? I mean you can go only so far without money and then

tips and others won't, they won't hear of it. And so it's rough that way. And then when you get a little bit outside New York like New Jersey or Connecticut you already find a difference there where you get a little bit more. And so a lot of people do that. There's the Shanghai Club in New Jersey or there's a lot of clubs in Connecticut, upstate New York.

MR: Yes. And there's the universities and so forth.

CS: Yeah. That's a whole different story.

MR: That's a different story, yeah. Well I've enjoyed talking to you today. Is there anything that you'd like to add on your own?

CS: It just seems like in all those years, you know there's so many different phases. I've had a lot of fun playing at some music festivals in U.K. and Switzerland and I'm looking into Germany now. There's been so many different experiences. I guess you can't cover it all in one interview, but I was pleased to be written up in several books. Royal Stokes has been a great promoter of women in jazz, including of my own career, doing as much as he could to recommend me to people.

MR: Have you ever thought about relocating?

CS: I think about it all the time but I don't know where to go. If somebody told me where to go, you know, I mean if I had a family, kids, grandkids, a husband, some incredible job offer. I mean I have absolutely no paradigms for, you know, parameters for where to go. So I don't go anywhere.

MR: I see.

CS: But I think about it all the time.

MR: Do you happen to know Rossano Sportiello?

CS: Oh sure. Yeah I love him, he's just a fabulous guy and a great player.

MR: But certainly more jazz players come here —

CS: Oh sure.

MR: Than go elsewhere.

CS: Sure. And then we go for tours elsewhere, but this city attracts players from everywhere. And Rossano I met actually in Ascona, Switzerland where he was playing. And I was in the press office, I was doing a little bit of — I had a little newspaper column and I wrote about the different acts and then I sat in and played a little bit. But he was playing there.

MR: I see.

CS: So that's where I first met him.

MR: Well it's been a pleasure, Carol.

CS: For me too.

MR: Thank you very much.

CS: Thank you so much.

CS: Well I hope so. Thanks.